



Water resources for the Neolithic Haġar Qim – Mnajdra cluster

Supplementary Material - Ethnography

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This document relates the information gathered in conversations with four individuals. These persons are referred as Individual 1 to 4 and remain anonymous. The conversations were ad hoc and informal, not organized interviews and the information they provided was registered the same day. The original notes were modified for anonymity purposes. The feature codes were added to reflect what they were talking about.

Individual 1

T1 is 1 meter deep. It is emptied every year and contains most sand and stones.

T2 is approximately 3 m deep. Water is pumped from the depressions in the south because in one or two weeks they are empty. In T2 the water stays.

T8 supposed to have had a fig tree.

The T2 bypass channel C10 was created 60 or 70 years ago.

The T2 south-east wall has inside small steps and handhelds to get in and out.

He thinks all tanks were covered but somebody broke the slabs. They were taken out.

The rectangular depressions (the vine trenches in the east of the plateau) are made for planting olive trees (when the Arabs introduced them). Afterwards the olive culture was replaced by cotton.

T4 slab 1 has 3x groups of 2 wedge holes. Technique employed in the past to split the rock.

He has no knowledge of any use of the rectangular depression B1.

T06 and T07 are the deepest and there is a likely a fissure at the bottom.

Somebody has been looking what was in it but only found some sherds like everywhere around the site.

The fields to the SE have the most clays. The stones of the wall around them are all coming from the fields.

T06 has rope-wear gutters. The workers of the north part of the Maghlaq quarry used to get water from it.

Individual 2

The tanks are currently used for the irrigation of the fields on both sides of the site.

The water is pumped from the big depressions to the south-west of the plateau (not surveyed) into the T5 and T2.

T5 and T2 were both covered in the past by slabs. For T5 they were in the length of the cistern.

Vandals have pushed the ones from T5 into the tank. Somebody has cut them in parts and removed them from the tank. He does not know what happened with the slabs of T2.

As far as he can remember the tanks T6 and T7 never contained water.

The tanks T2 and T5 were used for drinking water by the people working in the small quarries to the south below the plateau.

The rectangular shaped hole in T form (not surveyed) in the west of the plateau was used as a sparrow birth-trap. The net was setup in the gutter a few centimetres to the south of the hole. When the birds came drinking the net was flipped.

He thinks the west edge of the plateau was one of the places where the megaliths for Mnajdra were quarried. There are still a few detached blocks present.

The usage of a small tank before the main tank was a common practise. He did that himself with a cistern he dug in his fields to the north of the northern wall of the plateau. This cistern is at the bottom 5 m wide and 5 meters deep and plastered. The cistern is capturing the water flowing down the road.

The very long wall was made in the 80'ties.

The deep gutter C09 surrounding T2 was cut out in the 40's or 50's.

T2 was emptied in the summer of 2024. It had a 2-3 cm of sediment. This tank was also emptied in 2022.

T2 widens on the long side ± 0.5 meters on both sides.

Individual 3

The land around the site is a long term lease from the government. He thinks it is a lease for 200 years or so.

The U-shaped gutters with a hole in the middle are bird traps. (H06, G13, D13; D27, G19; one in the west, not surveyed).

One in L-shape seems unfinished (D16, C16).

The shallow gutters/scratches were covered with soil and mend to stimulate root grow in those directions.

T6 has tool mark patterns in the lower part. All tanks have the same pattern: upper part is well finished (no tool marks) but the widening lower part has many coarse tool marks.

T1 the upper part seems to have cemented fragments.

He has no explanation for the two connected parts (D05, G05 and D02, G02, D03, G01) to T1/D04.

He showed me the remains of a big fig tree in the south-west of the plateau. Currently young sprouts are growing from the original root.

T8 had a big fig tree in the past.

He showed me what according to him is the oldest tree on the plateau: a young vine sprout in the south-west just after the last depressions.

Individual 4

He told me about an underwater source at L'Ilsna he had seen probably in 2018. He could see the change in density where the water was coming out (the reflexion changes). One or two meters below the surface.